

» AFTER

Writers on both sides of the argument grew steadily more impassioned in their defense or condemnation of slavery.

LEGITIMIZING SLAVERY

Religious leaders across the South marshaled arguments such as **the existence of slavery in the Bible** and St. Paul's injunction to slaves to obey their masters as justification for enslavement.

Most presidents, Supreme Court justices, and Congressional leaders had been enslavers. The Constitution **sanctioned slavery** and promised to **protect private property**. A man's property—his slaves—should be protected wherever he went in the United States.

THE CASE FOR ABOLITION



HARRIET JACOBS

Black abolitionists, along with some white northerners, wielded Christianity to refute southern arguments. Maria W. Stewart, friend of influential Black activist and writer **David Walker** (see [The Fury of Abolition](#)), preached that America was "a seller of slaves and the souls of men." Harriet Jacobs' autobiographical *Incidents in the Life of a Slave Girl*, published in 1861, used the New Testament to draw attention to the hypocrisy of enslavers who sexually abused Black women.

VIOLENCE ERUPTS

The Compromise of 1850 averted conflict for the time being. But in 1854, the act that established the **territories of Kansas and Nebraska** provoked violent clashes between opponents and supporters of slavery. One prominent abolitionist involved in the fighting in Kansas was **John Brown**, who was subsequently hanged after gaining lasting notoriety for leading the [Raid at Harpers Ferry](#).